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UNGA

United Nations General Assembly



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INTRODUCTION

The United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) is the main deliberative body of the United Nations, consisting of delegates from all 193 member nations of the United Nations, where each country has an equal say regardless of its size and economic standing. Being the most representative organ within the United Nations structure, the UNGA acts as a platform for international debate, discussion, policy-making, and reaching a consensus on matters of global importance. During this conference, delegates will address an important issue facing the international community today, the establishment of regulations regarding Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS), which refers to weaponized technology that selects targets and launches attacks without any significant human involvement. The discussion on this agenda topic revolves around the need to establish international standards and possibly an international treaty regarding the use of LAWS. The discussions in this committee will ultimately determine if the international community will be able to reach a consensus on setting standards on new technology used in warfare before it becomes too common to affect the way wars are fought in the future. You, as a delegate, will represent your country, negotiate with other member states, and play an instrumental role in crafting international policies on regulation of Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems.



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HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

Rise of Artificial Intelligence in Warfare -

In the 2000s and 2010s, advances in AI and machine learning significantly improved autonomous targeting and navigation systems.

Military powers began heavily investing in AI-based defense technologies.

International Concerns -

In 2013, concerns about “killer robots” gained global attention after campaigns by civil society groups such as the Campaign to Stop Killer Robots.

Discussions on autonomous weapons formally entered the framework of the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW).

Group of Governmental Experts (GGE) -

In 2016, the UN established a Group of Governmental Experts under the CCW to discuss emerging technologies in autonomous weapons.

The GGE has since debated issues such as:

Meaningful human control

Accountability

Ethical implications

Compliance with International Humanitarian Law (IHL)

Recent Developments -

Several states, NGOs, scientists, and technology leaders have called for a legally binding treaty banning or regulating LAWS. Other states argue that existing international law is sufficient and that regulation should remain flexible.



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CURRENT SCENARIO

Today, autonomous military technologies are rapidly developing worldwide. Major military powers such as the United States, China, Russia, Israel, and South Korea are investing heavily in AI-enabled defense systems.

Examples include:

Autonomous drones

AI-assisted surveillance systems

Automated defense turrets

Swarm drone technology

Key debates currently include:

Should fully autonomous weapons be banned?

What qualifies as “meaningful human control”?

Can existing international law adequately regulate AI warfare?

Who is responsible if autonomous weapons commit war crimes?

Many nations from the Global South fear that unregulated AI weapons could widen military inequalities and destabilize international peace and security. At the same time, some technologically advanced nations believe restrictions could hinder innovation and national defense capabilities. No binding international treaty currently exists specifically governing LAWS.



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KEY TERMS

Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS)

Weapons capable of independently selecting and attacking targets without direct human intervention.

Artificial Intelligence (AI)

Technology enabling machines to simulate human intelligence and decision-making.

Meaningful Human Control

The principle that humans should retain oversight and control over critical decisions involving the use of lethal force.

International Humanitarian Law (IHL)

Rules governing conduct during armed conflict to protect civilians and limit unnecessary suffering.

Accountability

Determining legal and moral responsibility for actions committed by autonomous systems.

Autonomous Drone Swarms

Groups of AI-enabled drones capable of coordinating attacks independently.

Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW)

An international treaty framework discussing restrictions on weapons considered excessively harmful.



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Dual-Use Technology

Technology that can serve both civilian and military purposes.

Autonomous Warfare

The use of machines or systems that can operate and make combat-related decisions with limited or no human involvement.

Civilian Protection

Efforts to ensure non-combatants are not harmed during armed conflicts.

Binding Treaty

A formal international agreement that countries are legally required to follow.

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MAJOR STAKEHOLDERS

United States

Supports continued research and argues existing international humanitarian law is generally sufficient. Opposes a complete ban.

Stances:

Opposes a complete preemptive ban on LAWS.

Supports maintaining “appropriate levels of human judgment” rather than strict “meaningful human control.”

Believes autonomous systems can increase military precision and reduce soldier casualties.

Prefers non-binding guidelines instead of a legally binding treaty

Concerns:

Restrictions could weaken military superiority.

A ban may slow technological innovation while rivals continue development secretly.

Russia

Resists legally binding restrictions and emphasizes national security and military innovation.

Key Position:

Rejects proposals for a legally binding ban.

Argues that discussions on LAWS are premature because technology is still evolving.

Maintains that states should retain freedom to develop military technologies.

Concerns:

International regulations could disadvantage national defense programs.

Definitions of autonomy remain unclear and difficult to enforce.



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China

Publicly supports regulation discussions but maintains significant AI military development programs.

Key Position:

Supports negotiations regarding regulation of autonomous weapons.

Has shown partial support for restrictions on the use of fully autonomous lethal weapons.

Does not support limiting research and development activities.

Concerns:

Maintaining technological competitiveness with the United States.

Avoiding regulations that hinder national innovation and military modernization

Pakistan

Strongly supports a preemptive ban on LAWS due to concerns about regional stability and ethical implications.

Key Position:

Strongly supports a legally binding international treaty banning LAWS.

Believes machines should never make independent life-and-death decisions.

Calls for strict international oversight and accountability mechanisms.

Concerns:

AI weapons could trigger destabilizing regional arms races.

Developing countries may lack the resources to defend against advanced autonomous systems.

Increased risk of accidental conflict escalation.



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India

Advocates cautious discussion while balancing security interests, technological development, and strategic autonomy.

Key Position:

Supports continued international discussions and gradual regulation.

Avoids supporting an outright ban.

Emphasizes the need for “meaningful human control.”

Encourages balancing innovation with humanitarian obligations.

Concerns:

Regional security challenges involving neighboring powers.

The need to maintain technological and military competitiveness.

Risks of overregulation limiting defense modernization.

European Union

Generally favors stronger regulation and emphasizes ethical AI governance.

Key Position:

Supports ensuring meaningful human control.

Encourages international cooperation and transparency.

Some member states support legally binding restrictions, while others prefer flexible regulations.

Concerns:

Protection of human rights and civilian populations.

Preventing an uncontrolled global AI arms race.



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International Committee of the Red Cross

Calls for strict limits on autonomous weapons and stresses compliance with humanitarian law.

Key Position:

Supports legally binding international rules limiting autonomous weapons.

Calls for prohibition of systems that cannot comply with International Humanitarian Law.

Emphasizes preservation of human control over lethal force.

Concerns:

Civilian harm and accountability gaps.

Ethical and moral implications of machine-made killing decisions.

NGOs and Civil Society

Organizations such as the Human Rights Watch and the Campaign to Stop Killer Robots advocate for a legally binding ban.

Campaign to Stop Killer Robots

Calls for a complete global ban on LAWS.

Arguing machines should never decide to kill humans.

Pushes for legally binding international agreements.

Human Rights Watch

Highlights risks to human rights and civilian protection.

Warns of accountability gaps and misuse by authoritarian governments.



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QUESTIONS A RESOLUTION MUST ANSWER

A strong resolution on LAWS should address:

Should fully autonomous lethal weapons be banned, regulated, or permitted?

How can “meaningful human control” be clearly defined internationally?

Who should be held accountable for unlawful actions committed by autonomous systems?

How can civilian protection under International Humanitarian Law be ensured?

Should there be transparency requirements regarding AI military development?

How can smaller or developing nations be protected from an autonomous arms race?

What role should the United Nations play in monitoring compliance?

Should there be export controls on autonomous weapons technologies?

How can innovation in civilian AI continue while preventing military misuse?



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SUGGESTED RESEARCH AREAS

Delegates should research:

Existing International Humanitarian Law

The Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons and its meetings
on LAWS

National policies on AI warfare

Ethical concerns surrounding AI decision-making

Autonomous drone warfare in recent conflicts

Cybersecurity risks in autonomous systems

The role of private technology companies in military AI
development

Past arms control treaties such as:

Chemical Weapons Convention

Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty

Ottawa Treaty

Positions of major powers and regional blocs

Human rights implications of autonomous warfare

Official UN and CCW Resources

<https://disarmament.unoda.org/en/our-work/conventional-arms/legal-instruments/convention-certain-conventional-weapons>

This is the most important official UN resource for this agenda. It includes:

Information about LAWS discussions

Official meeting documents

Statements by countries

Reports of the Group of Governmental Experts (GGE)

Previous conference records



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<https://www.unoda.org/en/our-work/emerging-challenges/lethal-autonomous-weapon-systems>

Official UN page for LAWS

<https://www.ungeneva.org/en/news-media/news/2025/05/106320/politically-unacceptable-morally-repugnant-un-chief-calls-global-ban>

Secretary-General on ban of 'Killer Robots'

NGO's and Research Organizations

<https://www.stopkillerrobots.org/>

<https://www.icrc.org/en/document/autonomous-weapons-icrc-recommends-new-rules>

<https://www.hrw.org/topic/arms/autonomous-weapons-systems>

<https://www.hrw.org/topic/arms/killer-robots>



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CONCLUSION

In conclusion, Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS) have become one of the most important and controversial issues in modern warfare. While some countries believe these weapons can improve military efficiency and reduce risks for soldiers, others worry that allowing machines to make decisions about human lives is dangerous and unethical.

The world is still divided on whether such weapons should be banned, strictly regulated, or allowed under existing international laws. As technology continues to develop rapidly, the United Nations and its member states must work together to find a balance between security, innovation, and the protection of human rights and global peace.

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